and Ljubo from the Prologue – fled Eastern Europe during the early years of Communism. Because these were usually highly-educated people and patriots, they soon established ethnic associations and even political parties and shadow parliaments in exile. The Slovenian political emigrants in Argentina, smeared as traitors by the Communist authorities, developed an impressive system of schools, crèches, companies, publishing houses, radio stations, etc. – all in the Slovenian language. Scores of third- and fourth-generation children speak fluent Slovenian. (Poles all over the world have created even larger and more influential ethnic communities.) By the nature of things, these were, of course, people of staunch conservative views (as well as some liberals like Ljubo), and it was thus within the ranks of European Christian Democrats that they managed to find partners in the West who would listen to them. In fact, the all-European organisation of Christian Democratic parties even set up a committee to deal with the issues of Central and Eastern Europe where exiled politicians had the opportunity to meet Western politicians and lobby for their cause. (In the early years of the Cold War some of these exiles were also useful to the Western intelligence services.) In the late 1980s, many of them – by then growing old – served as links between Western politicians and government officials on the one hand and the new democratic political establishment that was emerging in Eastern Europe on the other.

These political emigrants did not, however, always find their homeland very welcoming. They were vigorously opposed by former Communists, who labelled them as traitors and extremists, but even the new democratic politicians sometimes found their presence embarrassing. They saw them as out of touch with the local situation, and harbouring expectations of what the new democracies could deliver that were simply too high, especially concerning the removal of all traces of Communist regime and redressing their losses, material and otherwise.

After the democratic changes and in particular after the entry of eight Central European countries into the EU, many of these countries would again see a similar emigration that, in the case of Bulgaria, Romania and the Baltic states, would amount almost to an exodus of the best and the brightest, now for economic reasons. In very much the same way as post-World War II emigration depleted these nations of some of the most industrious and educated individuals, the post-enlargement emigration